



DAVID BUTOW For The Times

MOURNERS gather to remember Oscar Omar Hernandez in an April 12 service at Immaculate Heart of Mary Church in East Hollywood. The boy’s family last saw him taking a train to help his coach make jerseys.

Young soccer player’s death devastates his community

Many wonder why the coach accused of killing the 13-year-old boy wasn’t scrutinized. Some youth league officials had suspicions.

BY EDUARD CAUCH, RICHARD WINTON AND NATHAN SOLIS

For years, the bright green turf of Whitsett Fields Park has served as a joyous hub for Los Angeles youth soccer — particularly for thousands of immigrant families in the San Fernando Valley.

On most weekends, the sprawling North Hollywood complex echoes with the shouts of hundreds of boys and girls, as vendors hawk aguas frescas, balloons and candy along the sidelines.

But recently, immense grief and worry have settled over this close Latin American community.

Just last week, a well-known coach and Salvadoran national was



Photo from the Hernandez family

OSCAR OMAR HERNANDEZ was a 13-year-old soccer player. His coach, charged with his murder, has not entered a plea.

charged with murder in the killing of 13-year-old soccer player Oscar Omar Hernandez during a lewd or attempted lewd act and then dumping the boy’s body in a roadside ditch in Ventura County. The coach, Mario Edgardo Garcia Aquino, who has not yet entered a plea, has also been charged with sexually assaulting another teen, and investigators say there are probably more victims who have yet to come forward.

The teen’s slaying has left many in the youth soccer community profoundly shaken. Some say their faith in a long-trusted institution has been broken, and they question why the coach wasn’t scrutinized more carefully before he was allowed to work so closely with children.

“We have never seen anything of

[See Killing, A10]

People hatch less eggs-pensive ideas for Easter

High prices inspire creative substitutions: Think dyed potatoes and marshmallows.

BY HEATHER PLATT

With a bird-flu-induced egg shortage that has caused prices to skyrocket — and consumers, for lack of a better word, to scramble — the term “egg hunting” takes

on new meaning this Easter. But will the dearth really have an impact on the pastel-hued spring holiday? According to the internet, where baskets of dyed Yukon Gold potatoes abound, the answer is yes.

“I think I’m going to ask my guests to bring [their own] eggs this year,” says Molly Page of South Pasadena, who hosts a yearly Ukrainian egg-dyeing party for her friends and children.

Many parents are giving

up on dyeing real eggs entirely, and some have taken to TikTok, posting videos of their kids coloring potatoes to the tune of “It’s the Hard Knock Life” while others open up egg cartons to reveal a dozen decorated marshmallows, golf balls and other egg alternatives.

Jet-Puffed marshmallow brand launched “Dip and Decorate” Easter marshmallow dyeing kits. For \$1.99 at Walmart, the kits include a 24-ounce bag of jumbo

marshmallows, six dye colors, two flavored drizzles, tongs and three food-safe markers in a pink egg crate labeled “Farm Fresh Marshmallows.”

Massachusetts-based company Jaju Pierogi posted a video of its pierogies submerged in Easter dye, proof that no one is immune to jumping on the bandwagon.

Though potato decorating seems the most wide-

[See Easter eggs, A8]

Stadium prices take Dodger fans out of ballgame



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

A POPCORN VENDOR makes the rounds last week at Dodger Stadium, where a family of four may pay about \$400 for a night out. In 2015, the average ticket price was \$29. A decade and two championships later, cheaper seats go from \$39 to \$159.

Costs fuel debate over whether the money is worth turning away so many families.

BY BILL SHAIKIN

Four days after the Dodgers won the World Series, and two days before he won the presidential election, Donald Trump was the guest on a sports podcast.

America’s major sports leagues, he said, were pricing out their most loyal customers.

“The leagues are not taking care of their fans,” Trump said on the “Let’s Go!” podcast. “They really aren’t. They’re making it impossible.”

The Dodgers are the greatest show in baseball, with an international tourist

Abrego Garcia will not return to U.S., Trump vows

Case of mistakenly deported man is seen as a winning political issue for Republicans.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration is embracing its legal fight over the fate of Kilmar Abrego Garcia, a man accused of gang membership who was deported to El Salvador last month, stating he is “not coming back” despite repeated judicial orders directing the administration to return him.

The case has fueled concern among Democrats and legal scholars that President Trump is increasingly willing to disregard U.S. courts. But the White House has leaned in further to the case in recent days, jumping on a messaging opportunity to pin Democrats as weak on immigration as popular opinion on deportations and the border shifts toward the right.

Nayib Bukele, El Salvador’s president and an ally to Trump, took part in that effort on Thursday when he allowed a Democratic senator, Chris Van Hollen of Maryland, to meet with

Abrego Garcia far from the confines of the maximum security prison where he is being held.

Cocktails were even served garnished with cherries and salted rims in photos of Abrego Garcia and Van Hollen that were released by Bukele’s office. But the festive drinks were not ordered by the table. Instead, they were delivered in the middle of their meeting by a Bukele aide. The El Salvadoran president then posted on social media that the comfort on display was evidence that Abrego Garcia was in good hands.

“Kilmar Abrego Garcia, miraculously risen from the ‘death camps’ & ‘torture’, now sipping margaritas with Sen. Van Hollen in the tropical paradise of El Salvador!” Bukele wrote on X. “Now that he’s been confirmed healthy, he gets the honor of staying in El Salvador’s custody.”

The episode was the latest play in a messaging war over Abrego Garcia’s case that is unfolding outside of the U.S. court system, which remains insistent that the Trump administration work to facilitate his return to the United States. Bukele, in a subsequent post, suggested he viewed the crisis as a

[See Abrego Garcia, A6]

L.A. man stabbed, shot and pushed off a cliff lives to testify

Bell Gardens resident’s story is an example of cartel violence on U.S. soil.

BY MATTHEW ORMSETH

High in the mountains above Los Angeles, Juan testified, the kidnappers pressed a gun against his stomach and handed him a phone after making a call on FaceTime.

Juan, who appeared at a preliminary hearing last month, in Los Angeles County Superior Court without revealing his last name, said he recognized his neighbor’s face on the screen that February morning last year. He said he had considered Francisco Javier Perez a friend.

What he didn’t know was that his neighbor, according to court documents, was a high-level drug trafficker with connections to an unnamed Mexican drug cartel.

Prosecutors charge that Juan was kidnapped, stabbed, shot and pushed off a cliff after Perez ordered him killed. But the men Perez allegedly hired botched the job — allowing Juan to escape and testify about what were supposed to be his last moments.

Perez’s attorney, Jennifer Gitlin, said she’d seen no evidence her client was affiliated with a cartel. He has pleaded not guilty to charges of attempted murder, kidnapping, robbery, drug trafficking and conspiracy to commit murder.

The case against Perez, who is accused of orches-

[See Juan, A6]

Lakers, Clippers in playoff grind

L.A.’s NBA teams begin their title quest with series against the Timberwolves and Nuggets. **SPORTS, D1, D6**

U.S. detains foreign student

UCLA says woman in graduate studies is held at Mexico border for unknown reasons. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

A landmark trial for Meta

Case between FTC and social media platform could unwind some of its most lucrative acquisitions. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather
Mostly sunny; warmer.
L.A. Basin: 73/54. **B8**



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